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I Used To Sleep 15 Hours A Day, Before I Knew About Coffee

My 'Sleep Genes' were against me and I never imagined how bad it was.

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“I have been like this...I think I can sleep for 15 hours and still not feel fresh and energized,” I said.

“Yes...I know...since you were a child, you have been taking those afternoon naps of 2 hrs. Sometimes you would fall asleep while having your lunch because it was time for your nap,” my mom said this and started laughing. We both laughed.

This was 4 years ago.

Why Do We Sleep?

Adenosine: A chemical that makes you want to sleep

As you get out of your bed, you start to move. You start to consume energy.

‘Adenosine’ is the byproduct of that energy consumption. Adenosine is also called the ‘sleep pressure’ chemical. It binds with some receptors and makes you feel relaxed and drowsy. This is called ‘homeostatic sleep pressure’.

Caffeine: A chemical that fights adenosine

Adenosine creates sleep. Caffeine collects your sleep for the whole day and then starts dumping it all at once, making you feel extremely sleepy. That is called the “caffeine crash”. An avalanche of sleep.

Me and Caffeine

I am blessed with ‘great sleep genes’. My father and grand father always have had a habit of an afternoon nap. My uncle and cousins sleep roughly 12 hours a day. *My great grandfather was popular in his village for the fact that he has magical abilities to sleep on demand.*

Even though I was aware of these terrible sleeping habits of my family, I never considered that this can be something related to the biology of our body. Instead I kept blaming myself. I kept fighting against my urge to sleep every afternoon and eventually losing that battle to adenosine.

At the age of 23, 2 years ago, I decided to leave home following the principle of ‘get rid of your comfort zone’ and came to Canada for higher studies. The leap of faith

worked. At least for sometime. The initial hike in excitement and thrill of starting a new life helped me stay awake all day long until after a month when I started losing the battle to adenosine again.

However on one Canadian summer evening, I was sitting at Tim Hortons with a friend. He was sipping his coffee. He asked me if I would have one; I said “may be”.

Then he shouted, “one medium iced coffee with 2 espresso shots please!”



That's it.

I couldn't sleep that night. Not just that, I had this strong urge in me to get things done.

For next few weeks, I entered the rabbit hole of caffeine's influence on humanity. I learned about how caffeine was discovered about 2000 years ago by an Arabian goat herder named Kaldi when he saw his goats being unusually energized after eating some mystical berries(coffee beans). I researched the morning routines of hundreds of high achievers and found for most of them, coffee is their go to and necessary morning drink.

All the long lines of cars at the Tim Horton's drive thru started making sense to me. Eventually, this research led me to the realization of how the west is leveraging the effect of coffee for centuries. *It might sound like an exaggeration but to me it felt like an unfair advantage they are getting and I was blind towards that for 23 years of my life!*

Just to understand the depth of what I felt, have a look at the following two videos that came across in my research. The first one explains the story of the origin of 'coffee breaks' while the second one is the scientific explanation of how coffee works.

This was 1 year ago. Since then I have been drinking coffee almost every single day. After countless experiments, I have created a list 5 tips to leverage coffee for improved alertness, productivity and mood in general.

Tips:

1. **Delay if you can:** After waking up, delay your first cup of coffee by approximately 90 minutes. Let your body wash off some adenosine on its own.
2. **Let Caffeine Plan your sleep:** Coffee keeps you alert roughly for 6–7 hours. I consume 2 cups a day to make sure the ‘crash’ happens right before its time for bed.
3. **How to be Calm:** Caffeine gives you ‘jittery’ alertness. If your work demands you to be calm and focused but highly productive and alert; pair caffeine with a supplement called L-theanine.
4. **The Daily Limit:** Daily advised limit of caffeine is 400 mg approx. ; consuming more than that causes elevated levels of anxiety and disturbed sleep.
5. **Surviving the Crash:** To survive the caffeine crash, consider taking a power nap of no more than 15 minutes whenever the crash happens.

Coffee has changed me. I was someone who would stay in bed for a couple of hours after waking up because I was afraid of facing the ‘brain fog’. Now, everyday I crave the 4 hours of the morning of me being mentally alert and wanting to get things done after a cup of coffee.

Coffee for me is not just about feeling alert but it is more about the elevated levels of happiness and presence of mind when the ‘brain fog’ disappears.

I hope this story makes you crave a cup of coffee.

Thank you for reading!

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